Good evening, my name is Justin Blanding and tonight I'm here to talk to you about an opportunity I was given to write and publish a book. Before I get started, I'd like to thank Mrs. Ussia, Dr. Caruso and so many other faculty and staff who helped me get this opportunity. My family also has continued to support me undoubtedly throughout this whole process and I'd like to thank all my family who guided me throughout the creation of this book. I'm a freshman at Wallenpaupack and I'm honored to stand before you today. I'm honored because obviously this is a rare opportunity that few are able to accomplish. But I'm honored because two generations ago, my existence as a biracial kid was outlawed by the Land of the free. I'm honored because where I am today, is a product of my ancestors' struggle.

Two summers ago, the country watched the murder of George Floyd, for 8:46 seconds, I, a 13 year old, watched a man beg for his life. A man crying for his mother and ultimately had his life taken from him. I sat there disgusted, but not surprised. My whole life I was stripped of the bliss of ignorance. Not because I wanted to, but I had to, to survive. For some the summer of 2020 was a time of awakening, but for me and many others like me, it was nothing new. Two years prior my unarmed cousin was shot and killed by the state of Virginia. His murder was legal, how can I feel safe?

No student should feel afraid to play in the park, yet Tamir Rice is dead, no kid should be afraid of visiting their family yet Trayvon Martin is dead, no one should be afraid of sitting in their apartment, yet Breonna Taylor is dead. No generation of my ancestors were born without the instilled fear from America. My book was created not only from the image of America, but also Wallenpaupack. In my hometown I'm taught to act a certain way, and speak a certain way just to get by. These are all factors of how I wrote this book, but it should not have been written. A 13 year old should not need to write a book about how a 13 year old feels threatened for his life at all times.

Some may see my title, The Land of the Free, as a mockery of this nation. But when you look deeper into this story, you see a message of hope. As I look around the room tonight, I see a lot of familiar faces, but a lot of parents are in this room. And as parents, I think you can agree that no child is perfect, and it is the parents duty to attempt to correct their problems. I look at this same idea in our country. It is the citizens job to say when the nation has a problem. As an American, the most patriotic thing to do is not to blindly state that our country is past our issues and free from the burdens of systemic racism, but to stand up and make a change for the better, and that is what the most loving parent does.

In conclusion, tonight I'm not here to give you an acceptance of such a personal accolade and accomplishment, but instead I'm here to say, while this is a mark of advancement for this nation and town, it is not the end, and change starting with our curriculum is our first steps towards equality. Thank you for your time.